STORIES OF THE HINDU GODS AND GODDESSES | VOLUME 1

Durga Katha

How Mother Durga defeated Mahishasura, Raktabeej, and the brothers Shumbha and Nishumbha



Three full stories from the Devi Mahatmyam, told as a storyteller tells them - to be read aloud, slowly, and together.

IMPROVED SECOND EDITION

WELCOME, LISTENER

Before the first story begins

Long before these stories were written in books, they were told. A grandmother told them while the evening lamp was lit. A traveller told them at a village well. And every autumn, during the nine nights of Navratri, they are told again - because in these stories, whenever darkness grows too proud and too strong, the Mother comes.

Her name in this book is Durga. *Durga* means "the one who is hard to reach, hard to defeat" - the fort no enemy can break. She is not only a warrior. She is Shakti, the living energy inside everything: the strength in a lion, the light in the sun, the courage that rises in an ordinary heart at the hardest moment. The gods themselves, the stories say, are strong because she lends them her strength.

That is why, in every story in this volume, the pattern is the same, and it is worth listening for. First, a demon wins a clever boon and mistakes it for forever. Then the world suffers, and the gods discover that all their power together is still not enough. Then - only then - they stop competing, join their light into one flame, and that flame takes the form of a woman. The demons laugh at her. The demons always laugh first. Remember that.

How to read this book aloud: Take one story an evening - each is five pages. Slow down at the lines in *italics*; they are the words spoken inside the story. Pause before a battle turns. And when a name is new, the guide on page 22 will help you say it and know who it is. **New in this edition:** spoken words are printed in **deep maroon** - when you see maroon, change your voice. Green **Last time we heard** boxes open Stories Two and Three, and each story ends with a Storyteller's Note and a Pause-and-Talk question.

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These tales come from the *Devi Mahatmyam*, also called the *Durga Saptashati* - seven hundred verses in praise of the Goddess, preserved inside the ancient *Markandeya Purana*. They have been retold here in fresh words, faithfully to the old telling.

STORY ONE

Mahishasura, the Buffalo Demon

How a boon with one missing word brought down a king of demons



There was a demon named Rambha who prayed for a mighty son, and the son born to him was mightier than any prayer had imagined. His name was Mahishasura - *Mahisha*, the buffalo, and *Asura*, the demon - because he could take the shape of a great black buffalo whenever he wished, hooves striking sparks from stone, horns like two curved moons. In his man's shape he was a king. In his buffalo's shape he was a mountain that could charge.

Mahishasura wanted what ambitious demons in these stories always want: not merely a kingdom, but *the* kingdom - earth below, heaven above, and no one left to say him no. And he knew the old way to get it. Power in battle could fail, so he would first buy safety with prayer.

For years he stood in penance, through heat and frost, calling on Brahma, the Creator. Hunger could not move him. Rain could not move him. At last Brahma appeared, as he must when devotion is that fierce, and said the dangerous words a god must say: ***"Ask, and it shall be given."***

Mahishasura asked to be unkillable. Brahma shook his head: everything born must die; even gods do not give what creation itself forbids. So the demon thought carefully - and here, listener, is where the whole story turns. ***"Then let my death come,"*** he said, ***"only at the hands of a woman. No god, no man, no demon, no beast shall ever kill me."*** He chose those words because he believed them safe. A woman, in his proud mind, was no warrior at all. Brahma, who sees further than the proud, simply said, ***"So be it."***

Heaven falls, and the gods do something they have never done



With the boon warming his chest, Mahishasura marched. His armies poured across the earth like a flood taking field after field. Kings bowed or broke. Then he turned his face upward, toward heaven itself, and defeated Indra, king of the gods, in open war. The gods fled their shining city. Their halls, their gardens, their thrones - all of it belonged now to a buffalo.

For a hundred years, the old telling says, this went on. A hundred years of tribute carried up to a demon's court. A hundred years of sages whispering their prayers instead of singing them.

At last the defeated gods went together to Brahma, and Brahma led them to the two greatest powers he knew: Vishnu, the Preserver, blue as deep water, and Shiva, the Destroyer, ash-smeared and still as a mountain. The gods poured out their humiliation. And as they listened, something began to happen that had never happened before.

Rage - bright, righteous rage - lit the faces of Vishnu and Shiva. From Vishnu's face streamed a great radiance. From Shiva's face streamed another. From Brahma, from Indra, from every god present, light poured out like rivers of fire leaving their banks. The lights did not scatter. They flowed *together*, into one blinding column of flame that filled the hermitage where they stood, and there, before their astonished eyes, the flame took shape.

It took the shape of a woman.

Her face formed from Shiva's light. Her hair from the god of death, her many arms from Vishnu's radiance, her strength from the earth itself. Every god had given his best light, and so she was not any one god's daughter or servant. She was all of them, gathered - and more than all of them, because she was the Shakti who had lent them their power in the first place, now come to collect it in person. The mountain cave rang with her first breath. The gods, who a moment ago had been refugees, bowed to her like children who have just seen their mother walk into the room.

Ten arms, ten gifts, and a laugh that shook the world



A goddess going to war must be armed, and each god armed her with a copy of his own greatest weapon, so that she carried heaven's whole armoury in her many hands. Shiva gave his trident, the *trishul* that never misses. Vishnu gave his spinning discus, the Sudarshana Chakra. Varuna, lord of waters, gave his conch, whose blast is the sound of creation itself. Agni, fire, gave a spear of flame. Vayu, wind, gave a bow and quivers that never empty. Indra gave his thunderbolt and his bell. The god of death gave his staff; the divine architect Vishwakarma gave an axe and armour no blade could pierce; the Himalaya himself, king of mountains, gave her jewels, garments - and her lion.

The lion deserves a sentence of his own. He was no pet. He was courage with a mane, and when Durga mounted him, heaven and earth understood each other: here was gentleness and ferocity in one rider, beauty that had decided, finally, to be dangerous.

Then Durga did something no frightened army expected. She laughed. The old verses say she laughed again and again, a full, ringing, unafraid laugh, and her conch blasted, and her bowstring sang, and the sound rolled through the three worlds like thunder that has learned joy. In his stolen palace, Mahishasura stopped mid-sentence. ***"What is that noise?"*** he demanded. His spies returned pale. A woman, they said. A goddess, on the mountain, armed like ten armies - laughing.

Mahishasura sent envoy after envoy, and his offers tell you exactly who he was. Join my court. Rule beside me. I will make you my queen. He could not imagine a power that did not want what he wanted. Durga's answer never changed, and it is worth hearing whole: she had vowed, she said, to belong only to one who could defeat her in battle - so if the buffalo king wanted her, he was welcome to come and try, and bring his armies, because she would not be leaving with an envoy. The envoys carried that answer back through a silence you could have cut with one of her swords.

The battle of the changing shapes



His generals went first, confident and doomed - Chikshura, Chamara, Udagra and others whose names the old poets kept because even the defeated deserve to be remembered as warning. Their armies came in waves: elephants, chariots, horsemen beyond counting. Durga's arrows met them like rain meeting a river, and her lion moved through the ranks the way a forest fire moves through dry grass - not cruelly, but completely. One by one the great generals fell. The field emptied. And at last the palace gates opened, and Mahishasura himself came out in his true anger, in the shape that named him: the buffalo, vast and black, shaking the earth at every step, tossing chariots with his horns, breathing out storms.

Now the famous duel began, and it is a duel of *shapes*. Durga bound him with her noose - and he was a lion, slipping free, claws out. She raised her sword against the lion - and he was a swordsman, laughing, blade in hand. She rained arrows on the swordsman - and he was an elephant, trumpeting, trunk sweeping soldiers aside like broom-straw. She cut at the elephant - and beneath her, sudden as a trap, the buffalo was back, charging, horns low, faster than thought.

Do you see his strategy? He had lived by changing - shape, plan, promise - whenever anything held him. Nothing could kill him because nothing could *keep* him. But Durga was not confused, and she was not hurried. She drank, the verses say, from her cup, and watched him with eyes red with battle-joy, the way a mother cat watches a mouse that believes the room is his. She was waiting for the one moment every shape-shifter must pass through: the moment *between* shapes, when he is neither one thing nor the other, and truly himself.

The moment between shapes



It came as the buffalo thundered in for the final charge. Durga sprang from her lion, light as a dancer, and landed on the buffalo's back, one foot pressing his great neck down into the dust. Beneath her the shape began to slip - buffalo dissolving, and out of its open mouth, half-formed, sword in hand, came the demon in his man's shape, still fighting, still proud, not yet whole.

That was the moment. That half-risen figure was Mahishasura with no shape to hide in and no boon left to quote. Durga's trident took him, swift and clean, the way lightning takes a tree it has chosen long ago. The buffalo body fell. The noise of the world, the poets say, stopped - and then the gods began to shout, and flowers fell from the sky like slow, glad rain, and the heavenly drums that demons had silenced for a hundred years sounded again.

The gods sang her praise, and in their hymn they asked the question every listener asks: ***why did you wait so long?*** Her answer shapes every story that follows in this book. She comes, she told them, whenever she is remembered with a whole heart in a time of trouble - not before she is called, and never after she is needed. Then she vanished from their sight, as a lamp's flame vanishes when it is blown out gently, leaving the light it gave behind it in the room.

On earth, the day of her victory is still kept. In Mysuru, whose very name carries Mahishasura's, a great festival crowns the hill where she is said to have fought. Across India the tenth day after Navratri's nine nights is Vijayadashami - the Day of Victory - when effigies of demons burn and children hear this very story by firelight.

What this story leaves with us

Mahishasura was not defeated by a stronger army. He was defeated by the one possibility his pride could not imagine. Every boon he won was real - and every one of them had a door in it shaped exactly like his contempt. The story asks its listeners a quiet question: what have we decided is "too small to matter", and is that where our own buffalo is waiting?

AFTER STORY ONE - MAHISHASURA

The ego that keeps changing shape



Storyteller's Note - for the grown-up reader

Read as a story about the inner life, Mahishasura is the stubborn ego - the part of us that must win, must be obeyed, and experiences every limit as an insult. Notice how he survives: not by strength alone, but by *changing shape*. Challenged as a buffalo, he is suddenly a lion; cornered as a lion, a swordsman; held as a swordsman, an elephant. Anyone who has argued with their own bad habits will recognise the technique. The habit, caught being greedy, reappears as tiredness; caught as pride, it returns dressed as hurt.

Durga's answer is quietly precise. She does not exhaust herself defeating every shape on its own terms. She stays centred, unhurried, and waits for the moment *between* shapes - the brief, honest instant when the ego is neither one disguise nor the other and can be seen as it is. The old poets put a boon around the same insight: pride is always undone through the very door it held in contempt, the possibility it refused to take seriously. What we dismiss as too small to matter deserves a second, more respectful look.

Where this story comes from: The Devi Mahatmyam (Durga Saptashati) in the Markandeya Purana - Madhyama Charita, Chapters 2-3: Mahishasura's boon, the fall of heaven, the Goddess's arising from the gods' combined radiance and the battle. The gods' hymn of praise follows in Chapter 4. Chapter numbering follows the standard Saptashati arrangement; some editions group the hymn with the battle chapters.

PAUSE AND TALK - BEFORE YOU TURN THE PAGE

Mahishasura survived by changing shape whenever he was held. Where does an old pattern in our own life do the same - and what might it mean, practically, to stop chasing each new shape and wait instead for the honest moment between them?

STORY TWO

Chanda-Munda and Raktabeej

The demon whose every drop of blood became another demon - and the goddess who solved him



LAST TIME WE HEARD...

Mahishasura, protected by a boon that only a woman could kill him, seized heaven for a hundred years. The gods joined their light into one flame - Durga. She fought his ever-changing shapes and defeated him in the moment between shapes, then vanished, promising to return whenever she is remembered with a whole heart.

Peace, in these stories, is a season, not an ending. Generations after Mahishasura, two new demon brothers rose to power: Shumbha and Nishumbha, and the third story of this book belongs to them. But before Durga could face the brothers themselves, she had to survive the strangest army ever sent against anyone - and that is this story.

It begins, surprisingly, with beauty and a riverbank. The Goddess, as Parvati, had gone to the Ganga to bathe, and there, from her own body, stepped forth a second, radiant form - Kaushiki, fair and luminous, who would do the fighting that lay ahead. This doubling is no accident. Again and again the Goddess defeats confusion by dividing herself clearly: the calm mother stays calm; the warrior walks out shining and does what warriors must.

Kaushiki took her seat on a Himalayan peak to wait, singing, her lion beside her, in full view of heaven and earth. She was not hiding. She was, if we are honest, *fishing* - and the bait worked exactly as she knew it would. Two demon captains passing below looked up, stopped, and forgot their errand entirely. Their names were Chanda and Munda, and they ran all the way back to their king with the report that would start a war: ***"Maharaj, on the mountain sits a woman more beautiful than any jewel in your treasury. Such a jewel should be yours."***

"Persuade her" - and the first armies



Shumbha, the elder brother, was cleverer than Mahishasura, which made him more dangerous and, in the end, no safer. He did not rage. He sent his smoothest messenger, Sugriva, with instructions that chill a listener who hears them rightly: *persuade her*. Tell her of my wealth. Tell her the gods themselves serve in my court. Tell her she may choose either brother - we are generous. Only bring her down from that mountain.

Sugriva climbed, bowed beautifully, and delivered it all. The Goddess listened with the patience of someone hearing weather in another country, and then gave the answer that echoes Mahishasura's story like a refrain: in a foolish moment, she said, she had made a vow - only the one who defeats her in battle, who pulls her chariot and matches her strength, may claim her. ***"So go back and tell your masters: if they want me, let them come the way warriors come. I will be exactly here."***

Sugriva carried the refusal home, and Shumbha's court heard it in the silence of men deciding someone must die for an insult. Nishumbha, the younger and hotter brother, wanted the whole army sent at once. Shumbha chose a general first: Dhumralochana, "Smoke-Eyes", with sixty thousand soldiers, and orders to bring her by the hair if she would not come by the hand.

Smoke-Eyes climbed the mountain bellowing threats, and the Goddess answered him with a single sound - ***"Hum!"*** - the seed-syllable of her anger, spoken almost softly. The old text is blunt about what happened: the sound itself was the weapon, and Dhumralochana was ash before he hit the ground. Her lion did the rest among the leaderless army. Sixty thousand had climbed up singing about glory. The mountain, that evening, was very quiet, and the Goddess had not risen from her seat.

The goddess who came out of a frown



Now Shumbha stopped underestimating her - a little. He sent the very captains whose report had started everything: Chanda and Munda, with the full demon host behind them, shields like a black sea. They surrounded the peak, and for the first time the Goddess rose, took up her great bow, and filled the sky with the sound of its string.

And then she frowned.

Hold that small detail, because the whole story turns on it the way Mahishasura's turned on a word. Out of that frown - out of the Goddess's forehead, dark as a storm at midnight, lean, terrible, garlanded, riding through the dark with a skull-cup in her hand - stepped *Kali*. Not a servant. Not a soldier. The Goddess's own anger, given a face so that it could do its work without troubling her smile. The demons named her in terror as they ran: this was Chamunda, slayer of Chanda and Munda, for within the hour she had done exactly that - swept through their army like the night itself had learned to fight, and laid the two captains' defeat before Kaushiki's feet.

But the war had only found its true shape. From the gods, watching, help now came in a form worthy of the moment: the Matrikas, the Divine Mothers - the female energies of the great gods themselves. Brahmi from Brahma, Maheshwari from Shiva, Kaumari, Vaishnavi, Varahi, Indrani - each on her own mount, each with her god's weapons, seven mothers descending in a line of light. The battlefield, which had held one goddess against an army, now held a family. The demons' poets, had any survived, might have written that the universe had sent its mothers to collect its children. Shumbha's answer, instead, was to unleash the one weapon he had been saving - the demon nobody could kill twice, because he never stayed killed once.

Raktabeej: the battle you win by losing



His name explains him: *Rakta*, blood; *Beej*, seed. Raktabeej had won, by long penance, a boon stranger than any armour. Every drop of his blood that touched the earth would rise up as another Raktabeej - full-grown, full-armed, full of the same fury - the instant it fell. He did not need an army. Given one wound, he *became* one.

Think, before we go on, about what that means for the goddesses facing him. Every skill they had was now a mistake. Strike him with the discus: a hundred drops, a hundred demons. A perfect sword-cut, the kind a warrior trains a lifetime for: a battalion. The Matrikas fought magnificently and the field filled faster than they emptied it, until the ground, the poets say, seemed to be manufacturing the enemy - Raktabeej laughing in ten thousand throats at once, each copy as fresh as the first, the original strolling untouched behind his own multiplying wounds.

It is the most frightening moment in all three of our stories, precisely because it is so quiet in its logic. There was no blow strong enough. Strength was the problem. The goddesses were not losing to a stronger enemy; they were losing to their own success, one perfect strike at a time.

> *"Mother," Kaushiki said at last to Kali, "the way we are fighting is feeding him. So we will change what fighting means."*

What she asked Kali to do sounds, at first, like a smaller thing than battle. Kali was to open her mouth wide - impossibly wide, the way night opens - stretch out her tongue across the whole field, and *catch*. Every drop, before it touched earth. Meanwhile Chamunda would move through the copies with her cup held ready, gathering what fell. The goddesses would still strike - oh, they would strike - but now every wound would end in a mouth or a cup, not in soil. Raktabeej's boon had one condition hidden inside it, as all boons do: the blood must *reach the ground*. Kaushiki had not found a stronger weapon. She had found the condition - and stepped around it, the way a river steps around a stone.



Not one drop reached the earth

The battle that followed is the one listeners lean forward for, and it deserves to be pictured slowly. Across a field black with copies, Kali moved like a storm made of hunger, her tongue a red road along which nothing reached the ground. Strike - catch. Strike - catch. The Matrikas learned the new rhythm within moments, mothers passing the wounded demon's falling life from blade to cup to tongue the way villagers pass buckets to a fire, hand over hand, without a wasted motion. And the field, which had been filling, began - for the first time - to empty.

Raktabeej felt it before he believed it. His laughter went first. Then his certainty. He charged Kali himself, and she received him the way the sea receives a stone. He sprang up and struck at Kaushiki, and Kaushiki, smiling for the first time in the whole battle, took him on the point of her trident - and lifted, and held him *above the earth he needed*, while every last drop drained where drops could do no harm.

When it was done, there was one body, and then not even that. No army rose. The silence afterward, the old singers say, was so complete that the goddesses could hear the Matrikas' mounts breathing, and far above them the first, relieved laughter of the gods.

Yet notice what the story does *not* do: it does not end the war. Two brothers still sat in their fortress-palace, and they had now lost their messengers, their generals, their captains, their secret weapon, and their temper. Shumbha, hearing the whole tale from the few who crawled home, stood up from his throne and said the words that seal the fate of every demon in this book: ***"Then we go ourselves."***

What this story leaves with us

Some problems in a life are Raktabeej problems: every angry answer makes two more, every hasty cut multiplies the trouble. The goddesses did not win by hitting harder. They won by pausing - in the middle of a battle - to ask what was feeding the enemy, and then refusing to feed it. Kali's part matters too: the anger we are ashamed of, given a clear task and a clear limit, became the very thing that saved everyone.

AFTER STORY TWO - CHANDA-MUNDA AND RAKTABEEJ

The trouble that feeds on how we fight it



Storyteller's Note - for the grown-up reader

Raktabeej is the most modern demon in this book. He stands for every trouble that multiplies precisely *because* of how it is struck: the argument where each reply breeds two more, the resentment rehearsed until it has a family, the anxious habit that grows stronger every time we attack it in panic. His boon is only ours, exaggerated - whatever is fed with attention, urgency and blood-heat tends to rise again in more copies.

So the goddesses win by containment, not by greater force. Kali's outstretched tongue and Chamunda's cup are a discipline: receive what is falling without passing it on; let nothing reach the ground where it can seed the next round. And notice *who* does the containing - anger itself, Kali, born from the Goddess's own frown. The story does not ask us to have no anger. It asks that anger be given a clear task and a clear limit, and be set to catching drops instead of spilling them.

Where this story comes from: The Devi Mahatmyam, Uttama Charita (the Shumbha-Nishumbha cycle, Chapters 5-13): Chapter 7 tells of Chanda and Munda and Kali's naming as Chamunda; Chapter 8 is the Raktabeej battle, where the Matrikas fight beside her and not one drop is allowed to reach the earth.

PAUSE AND TALK - BEFORE YOU TURN THE PAGE

Think of one recurring argument, worry or habit that seems to multiply whenever it is met head-on. What would 'catching the drop' look like in the first ten seconds - what, exactly, would each of you do, or refuse to do?

STORY THREE

Shumbha and Nishumbha

The last two brothers - and the goddess who finally stood alone



LAST TIME WE HEARD...

Kaushiki refused King Shumbha's messengers: only one who defeats her in battle may claim her. His general Smoke-Eyes fell to a single sound. Kali stepped from the Goddess's frown and destroyed Chanda and Munda; and when Raktabeej multiplied with every drop of blood, she caught every drop before it touched the earth. Now the brothers come themselves.

Every army has a morning after. For Shumbha and Nishumbha, it came with a battlefield report no king wants to hear twice: Dhumralochana ash, Chanda and Munda destroyed, Raktabeej - Raktabeej, their impossibility - gone, and the Divine Mothers themselves now fighting beside the woman on the mountain.

Understand the brothers before you judge them, for the story does. They were not fools, and they were not cowards. By penance and by arms they had taken heaven from the gods, as Mahishasura had; they had ruled long enough to believe ruling was their nature. Nishumbha, the younger, loved glory the way a flame loves oil. Shumbha, the elder, loved *ownership* - the world filed neatly as his property, including, he had decided, its most beautiful goddess. What neither brother could do was the one thing that might have saved them: hear the word *no* as information instead of insult.

So now they did the honourable, fatal thing. They stopped sending others. The whole remaining might of the demon world - the poets give the host in rivers of chariots, elephants and horse - poured out behind the two brothers in person, banners up, conches blowing, toward the mountain where the Goddess waited, unhurried, polishing nothing, fearing nothing, her lion asleep in the sun like a house-cat. She woke him with one hand as the ground began to tremble. ***"Come,"*** she said to him, in the verses' spirit if not their letter. ***"They have brought the whole story to us at last. Let us finish it properly."***

Nishumbha, the beloved brother



The last great battle of the Devi Mahatmyam is not a blur, and the old telling does not treat it as one. It moves the way grief moves - blow, pause, blow. The Matrikas blazed at the front, each a small sun of her own colour. Kali ranged where she was needed most. The demon host, for all its ruin, fought as soldiers fight when their kings are watching from the front rank instead of a throne: terribly well.

Nishumbha came at the Goddess in his chariot like a comet with a grudge. His arrows broke on her armour. His finest spear she caught - caught, listener, in one hand, as you or I might catch a thrown fruit - and, smiling, snapped his heart open with his own weapon returned by hers. The poets do not rush past what happened next, and neither shall we. From Nishumbha's fallen body, in the wonder-logic of these tales, a last warrior-spirit rose up crying ***"Stay!"*** - loyalty outliving its own body - and the Goddess stilled that too, gently and completely, the way one closes a door against a storm.

Then the sound the whole war had been travelling toward arrived. It was not a war-cry. It was Shumbha, the elder brother, the careful one, the owner of the world - screaming his brother's name across the field with everything his pride had saved up for a lifetime finally spent in one moment. He did not run. Credit him, as the story does, with this much: he charged. Grief made him faster than glory ever had. He came at the Goddess the way the sea comes at a cliff, and for a while - the verses honour him with this - the duel between them shook the very mountains that had lent her the lion.

Chandika - for that is the Goddess's fierce name in these chapters - met him weapon for weapon, and neither yielded the width of a hair. The gods above stopped their drumming. This was no longer an army's war. It was two wills, and one of them was about to discover what the other one was.

"You fight with borrowed strength!"



It was Shumbha himself who spoke the line that ends the war - though he meant it as an insult, and it became the Goddess's invitation. Breathless, bleeding glory from a dozen places, he looked at the ring of shining mothers around her and sneered the most human sentence any demon speaks in this whole book:

> *"Proud woman! You fight with the strength of others. Take away your borrowed goddesses, and what are you?"*

Every listener should feel the trap in that taunt, because it is one we set for ourselves. How often do we dismiss what saves us - help, love, community, grace - as "borrowed", as if standing alone were the only honest way to stand? The Goddess did not argue. She smiled the smile that had ended Raktabeej's laughter, and answered with the deepest truth in all three stories:

"Borrowed? Foolish king - look properly. There is no 'other' here. I alone exist in this world. Everything you see is my own power, wearing faces. These mothers are myself, as the waves are the sea. And what is mine, I may call home."

And she did. One by one, in full view of both armies, the Matrikas walked into her light and were gone - Brahmi, Maheshwari, Kaumari, Vaishnavi, Varahi, Indrani, and terrible Chamunda last of all - the way rivers enter the sea without ceasing to be water. The battlefield held its breath. Where an army of goddesses had stood, now one woman stood, alone on the field exactly as Shumbha had demanded, more radiant than all of them together had been. The sneer died on the demon king's face as understanding arrived, a lifetime too late: he had not reduced her. He had *concentrated* her. He had asked, with his last cleverness, to face the Goddess entire and undivided - and his wish, like Brahma's boons, was granted precisely as spoken.

Alone against the Goddess

The final duel of Shumbha and Durga is told in the old verses with an awe that slows the language down, and a storyteller should honour that pace. No armies interfere now. The field belongs to two figures and the dust.

He fought - let it be said plainly - magnificently. A hundred arrows she split in the air. His sword-work would have carved its way through any heaven he had conquered before. Again and again he closed with her, and again and again she turned him, unhurried, the way an elder turns an eager student, until at last she lifted him - lifted the king of the three worlds, armour, crown and all - whirled him in a great circle above her head as a potter whirls a wheel, and dashed him down upon the earth he had claimed to own.

Even then he rose. Even then - broken, crown rolling in the dust - Shumbha got to his feet and came at her with his fists, because there was nothing left in him to surrender *with*. It is almost possible to pity him in that moment, and the story lets you: pride that has lost everything except itself will still choose ruin over bending. The Goddess did not prolong it. Her trident - Shiva's own, given on the first morning of the first story in this book - ended the last demon king of the age, swift as mercy disguised as lightning.

Silence. Then the sky cleared in a way the poets reach for their largest words to describe: rivers ran clean, fires burned steady on altars that had smoked with fear for years, the sun stood out like a lamp newly trimmed, and from a heaven that was theirs again the gods rained flowers and sang. The Gandharvas, heaven's musicians, played. The Apsaras danced. If you have ever stood outside on the first clear morning after a long storm, when the whole world smells washed - you already know the exact feeling this page of the old book is describing, and you know why people have kept telling it for well over a thousand years.



A storyteller's pause: Ask your listener here - *when Shumbha demanded she stand alone, did he make her weaker, or did he finally see her clearly?* There is no wrong answer. That question is the story, still working.

The promise she left behind



The gods came down in their chariots of light and did what gods in these stories always do at the end: they sang, and then, like children who have learned something, they asked for more. ***Mother,*** they said, ***you have saved the three worlds three times over. Grant us one thing more - a way to call you, when the next darkness learns to walk.***

Her answer is the reason this book can promise a second volume without inventing anything. Whenever, she told them, a demon terror rises again to trouble the world, she will take form again and destroy it - and she named, in the old hymn, form after form she would yet come in, a procession of names that devotees still recite: the Goddess born of a sage's house, the Goddess of the Vindhya mountains, the Goddess who is the hunger and the harvest, the bee-dark Goddess, the Mother who will come when the world is at its driest and most afraid. Each name is a story somebody, someday, will ask a storyteller for - perhaps on another evening, perhaps in this very room.

For herself she asked for something smaller, and it tells you who she is better than any battle. Whoever reads or hears these stories with a whole heart, she said, let trouble leave their house the way darkness leaves a room when a lamp comes in - not argued with, not fought, simply unable to stay. Then she withdrew, as light withdraws at evening without going anywhere, and the gods returned to a heaven that felt, for the first time in an age, like a gift instead of a possession.

What this story leaves with us

Shumbha's taunt backfired because Durga's strength was never borrowed - it was shared, which is a different thing entirely. The people and powers that stand with us in a hard season are not a weakness in our story. Gathered honestly, they are what we are made of. And standing "alone", when the moment truly comes, turns out to mean standing as everything we have ever loved, at once.

AFTER STORY THREE - SHUMBHA AND NISHUMBHA

Pride that wanted to own the Goddess



Storyteller's Note - for the grown-up reader

Shumbha's flaw is subtler than Mahishasura's rage, and closer to ordinary life. He is possessiveness: the wish not merely to meet beauty, goodness or love, but to *own* them - to have the Goddess brought down from her mountain and installed in his treasury, like the finest of his jewels. His messengers do not woo; they inventory. Whenever we try to possess what can only be honoured - a partner, a child, a phase of life, even our own past happiness - we are speaking Shumbha's language, and the answer comes back the same: come the way warriors come, or do not come.

His last taunt carries the story's deepest teaching. 'You fight with borrowed strength' assumes that strength shared is strength diminished. Durga's reply gathers the whole book into one line: there was never any 'other' to borrow from. The people, teachers and loves who stand with us in a hard season are not scaffolding around the real self. Gathered honestly, they are what the self is made of - as the waves are not borrowed from the sea.

Where this story comes from: The Devi Mahatmyam, Uttama Charita, Chapters 5-13: the brothers' rise and the Goddess's refusal (Ch. 5-6), the final battles and Nishumbha's fall (Ch. 9), Shumbha's fall after the goddesses merge back into one (Ch. 10), and the Goddess's promise to return, in the Narayani hymn (Ch. 11). Closing blessings follow in Chapters 12-13.

PAUSE AND TALK - BEFORE YOU TURN THE PAGE

Shumbha wanted to own the Goddess rather than honour her. Where do we catch ourselves trying to own something - a person, a place, a season of life - that can only be honoured, enjoyed, and in the end let be free?

What these stories leave with us



Three demons, three different defeats - and now the lamps of Navratri make sense as more than decoration. For nine nights each autumn, families keep this victory the way you keep a fire in cold weather: by tending it together. In Gujarat the garba dances circle all night around a lamp that stands for the Mother. In Bengal, Durga arrives in magnificent clay splendour for Durga Puja and is bid farewell at the river with tears and sweets in the same breath. In Mysuru the palace blazes with light. Everywhere, on the tenth day - Vijayadashami, which much of India also keeps as Dussehra - the message is spoken aloud one more time so that children hear it before the year turns: *goodness, when it finally stands up, wins.*

But sit with the three stories a moment longer, as adults do after the tale is done, and notice how precisely they differ. Mahishasura teaches about the blind spot of pride: the contempt we build into our plans becomes the door our downfall uses. Raktabeej teaches about multiplication: some troubles feed on our very way of fighting them, and wisdom begins by changing the fight, not enlarging it. Shumbha teaches about wholeness: the strength we share is not borrowed, and the self we are when everything gathers is not smaller than the crowd - it is the sea the rivers were always travelling toward.

And over all three stands the Mother herself, who is the real reason to return to this book. She is fierce without cruelty - notice that she never once fights before she is refused every other road. She is patient without weakness - she answers envoys, honours vows, and waits through a hundred years of being needed before she is called with a whole heart. She laughs. In a literature full of trembling gods, Durga laughs in the face of the assembled darkness, and children who hear that laugh at bedtime sleep, somehow, better for it.

Names and words - a listener's guide

Say them slowly and without worry; the stories forgive every accent. The guide below follows the order the names first appear.

Durga (DUR-gaa) - The Goddess as warrior-mother; "the unbreakable fort". The form taken by Shakti when the world must be defended.

Shakti (SHUK-ti) - Divine energy itself; the power by which everything moves, shines and lives. In these stories, Shakti is female, and she is supreme.

Asura (a-SU-ra) - A demon: a being of great power and greater appetite, who takes what belongs to all for himself alone.

Mahishasura (ma-hi-SHAA-su-ra) - "Buffalo demon". Could change shape at will; killed by Durga after his boon excluded every killer except a woman.

Brahma, Vishnu, Shiva - Creator, Preserver and Destroyer: the three great gods who, together, could not do what the Goddess did alone.

Indra - King of the gods, lord of storms and the thunderbolt, twice a refugee in this book.

Trishul / Sudarshana Chakra / Conch - Durga's trident from Shiva, spinning discus from Vishnu, and conch whose sound announces creation.

Parvati and Kaushiki - Parvati is the Goddess as Shiva's gentle consort; Kaushiki is the radiant warrior-form who steps out of her in Story Two.

Kali and Chamunda - The Goddess's anger given form, born from Durga's frown; named Chamunda after defeating Chanda and Munda.

Chanda and Munda - Demon captains whose flattering report to Shumbha started the second war.

Matrikas - The Divine Mothers: the female energies of the great gods, who fight beside Durga and finally merge back into her.

Raktabeej (RUK-ta-beej) - "Blood-seed". Every drop of his blood that touched earth rose as a new copy of him.

Shumbha and Nishumbha (SHUM-bha, ni-SHUM-bha) - The demon brothers of Stories Two and Three; the elder ruled by pride of ownership, the younger by hunger for glory.

Dhumralochana - "Smoke-Eyes", the general destroyed by the single sound of the Goddess's anger.

Navratri and Vijayadashami - The nine nights of the Goddess's festival, and the tenth day, the Day of Victory that closes it.

Devi Mahatmyam / Durga Saptashati - "The Greatness of the Goddess" / "Seven Hundred Verses to Durga": the ancient text, within the Markandeya Purana, from which all three stories come.

About this book, and what comes next

This improved second edition adds the Raktabeej climax picture the first edition lacked, a Storyteller's Note and a Pause-and-Talk question after every story, 'Last time we heard' recaps, and maroon styling for spoken words - so the reader's voice can change the moment a character speaks. Durga, Kali and Kaushiki keep one face, one crown and one lion throughout, from the character design on the cover.

The three stories in this volume follow the great arc of the *Devi Mahatmyam*: Mahishasura from its middle section, and Chanda-Munda, Raktabeej, Shumbha and Nishumbha from its final section. They have been retold here - scenes opened out, dialogue given room to breathe, the boons and their hidden conditions made clear - while keeping the old telling's order, names and outcomes. Nothing in the endings has been softened or invented: the demons fall where the ancient verses fell them, and the Goddess's promise at the end is her own.

A note for the reader aloud: the demons' defeats are told without lingering on wounds, as the tradition itself usually tells them to families - the wonder in these stories was never the violence. It is the laugh on the mountain, the frown that becomes a goddess, the drop that must not reach the ground, and a king demanding that his enemy stand alone, and getting his wish.

Waiting in the next volumes

The Hindu story-world this book opens is very large, and Durga herself has already promised, on page 19, to return in more forms. Ahead lie, among many others:

Shiva and Parvati - the wedding on the mountain, and Ganesh's birth	Volume 2
Vishnu's avatars - the fish, the tortoise, the boar who lifted the earth	Volume 2
Narad, the travelling sage whose news starts a hundred stories	Volume 3
Durga's further forms - and the demons Madhu and Kaitabha, from the very first verses	Volume 3

Until then, keep the custom this book was made for: one story, one evening, read aloud to someone you love - and when the last page turns, blow out no lamp too quickly. The Goddess, the old singers say, likes a house where her stories are still being discussed after they end.

Jai Mata Di - Victory to the Mother.